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Newsom expands 'Trump-proof' session for wildfire response

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Gov. Gavin Newsom on Monday expanded a special session for California lawmakers to respond to deadly wildfires tearing through the Los Angeles area and asked the legislature to approve $2.5 billion to aid response and recovery efforts.

Newsom had originally called the special session in November to funnel millions in additional dollars to the state Department of Justice in preparation for incoming President Donald Trump's second term, which begins next Monday.

"California is organizing a Marshall Plan to help Los Angeles rebuild faster and stronger - including billions in new and accelerated state funding so we can move faster to deliver for the thousands who've lost their homes and livelihoods in these firestorms," the governor said in a statement. "To the people of Los Angeles: We have your back."

The Marshall Plan was a post-World War II American initiative to help rebuilding Western European nations' economies.

Top legislative Democrats made statements in support of the expanded special session. Senate President pro Tem Mike McGuire called the funding request from Newsom "a down payment that will kickstart the clean-up of neighborhoods and start the process of rebuilding lives."

"We must ensure Angelenos and Southern Californians can restore their lives and communities as quickly as possible," said Speaker Robert Rivas, who visited the devastation in the LA area over the weekend.

Republican lawmakers had earlier urged Newsom to call a special session on wildfire response.

Earlier Monday, Democratic lawmakers announced an agreement advancing a $50 million fund to prepare the state for potential litigation with incoming President Donald Trump, who takes office next week.

Newsom called the special session in November to shore up legal resources and defend against attacks on reproductive health care, climate change policies, and immigrant communities, all of which Trump repeatedly criticized on the campaign trail.

Bonta previews lawsuits

Attorney General Rob Bonta gave a preview Monday of the earliest lawsuits he expects to file against the Trump administration, including fighting Trump's desire to end birthright citizenship and to deploy the U.S. military to deport unauthorized immigrants.

He also mentioned preparing litigation to protect California's toughest-in-the-nation vehicle emissions standards and to fight against potential use of the Comstock Act, a 19th century law first implemented to ban mailing obscene material, to prohibit mailing medication, something anti-abortion conservatives have called for.

"He's told us what he'll do," Bonta said of Trump during a conversation with The Sacramento Press Club. "Many of those things are unlawful."

Sen. Scott Wiener, a San Francisco Democrat, on Monday announced amended legislation to provide $25 million in funding in grants for local legal aid agencies. That bill will complement one put forth by Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel, an Encino Democrat, that calls for the state to provide $25 million in funding for the Department of Justice.

Wiener drew a direct line between the additional funding and Trump's previous threats to withhold federal disaster relief aid as the death toll from the ongoing Los Angeles wildfires reached 24.

"National MAGA Republicans wasted no time politicizing the horrific tragedy unfolding in Los Angeles. As the fires burned, the President-elect, his allies, and senior Congressional Republican officials proposed withholding California's disaster aid and imposing unprecedented conditions on this humanitarian relief," Wiener said. "These inhumane threats show yet again why California must be prepared to counter the cruel and prejudicial attacks the incoming administration is preparing to launch against California."

So far, Trump has not threatened to cut off money for wildfire victims, who are eligible to apply for federal relief after President Joe Biden signed off on Newsom's request to declare a federal disaster last week.

But Trump has repeatedly threatened to block California's federal funding if Newsom doesn't capitulate to his demands to divert water to farmers. House Speaker Mike Johnson, a Louisiana Republican, told reporters Monday that he personally believed "there should be conditions" on disaster relief aid for California.

GOP blasts special session

Earlier Monday afternoon, legislative Republicans criticized Newsom for calling a special session to "Trump-proof" the state. All 28 Republicans in both chambers of the legislature signed a letter to Newsom Saturday calling on him to increase funding for wildfire prevention and home hardening, expedite fire suppression projects and increase criminal penalties for arson and fire negligence.

"We should not be distracted by a special session to pay more government lawyers to sue Donald Trump. We need to do more to help our fellow citizens and have real solutions for this catastrophe that we've faced far too much in this state," Assembly Republican Leader James Gallagher said at a news conference Monday.

Gallagher specifically called for exempting fuels reduction projects from the California Environmental Quality Acts, or CEQA, to speed up forest management and dry fuels removal.

Trump falsely accused Newsom of hampering officials' response to the fire by not signing a so-called "water restoration declaration" that he said would allow for water to "flow" from the northern part of the state into Southern California.

Newsom's office called this "pure fiction." His office did not immediately respond to a request for comment about the new legislation. Newsom remained in the Los Angeles area Monday to oversee the emergency response.

The governor invited Trump in a letter sent Friday to see the wildfire destruction firsthand. Trump did not immediately respond.

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